EMPLOYEE HANDBOOK

Sample Policies, Workplace Standards & Procedures

Organization	Example Company (fictional)
Version	1.0 — Sample template
Effective date	To be completed by the organization
Policy owner	Human Resources

Important template notice

This handbook is a fictional sample intended for drafting, training, and document-search testing. It is not legal advice and is not ready for adoption without review. Employment requirements vary by jurisdiction, contract, workforce, and industry. The organization should have qualified HR and legal reviewers adapt these policies, fill in local details, and ensure consistency with applicable law and existing agreements.

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1. Purpose, Scope & Guiding Principles

This handbook summarizes example workplace expectations and administrative procedures for employees of Example Company. It is intended to help employees understand common processes, where to seek support, and how to raise concerns. It applies to employees unless a written agreement, local addendum, or applicable law provides otherwise. Contractors, interns, and temporary staff should follow the provisions that apply to their engagement.

The company aims to maintain a workplace that is respectful, safe, inclusive, transparent, and compliant with applicable law. Employees are expected to act honestly, treat others fairly, protect company and customer information, and raise genuine concerns in good faith.

2. Employment Practices & Equal Opportunity

Equal opportunity

Employment decisions should be based on role-related criteria, qualifications, performance, and business needs. The company prohibits unlawful discrimination and retaliation and will follow applicable equal-employment requirements.

Hiring and onboarding

Candidates should provide accurate information relevant to employment. New employees must complete required documentation, policy training, and role-specific security or safety training within the timelines communicated by HR.

Employment records

Employees should promptly notify HR of changes to contact details, emergency contacts, tax or payroll information, and other records required for employment. Access to personal records is limited to authorized purposes.

Work authorization and accommodations

Employees must provide legally required work-authorization documentation where applicable. Requests for reasonable accommodation, accessibility support, or religious observance adjustments should be directed to HR and handled in accordance with applicable law.

3. Professional Conduct & Conflicts of Interest

Standards of conduct

Employees should communicate professionally, act with integrity, keep commitments, use sound judgment, and avoid behavior that threatens safety or undermines a respectful workplace.

Conflicts of interest

Employees must disclose actual, potential, or perceived conflicts, such as outside work that competes with the company, personal financial interests in a supplier, or decisions involving close relatives. The company will review disclosures and determine appropriate safeguards.

Gifts and business courtesies

Employees may not offer or accept gifts, payments, favors, or hospitality that improperly influence a business decision. Any monetary thresholds and approval requirements must be set by the company and comply with applicable law.

Fraud, bribery and improper payments

Falsification of records, theft, bribery, kickbacks, and misuse of company funds are prohibited. Suspected misconduct should be reported through a designated reporting channel.

4. Working Hours, Attendance & Remote Work

Schedules and attendance

Managers communicate normal working hours, breaks, timekeeping rules, and coverage expectations. Employees should arrive or sign in on time, record working time accurately where required, and notify their manager promptly about absence or delay.

Overtime and rest periods

Overtime must be approved and recorded according to company procedure. Pay, overtime eligibility, breaks, and rest periods are governed by applicable law and employment agreements; this handbook does not waive statutory rights.

Flexible and remote work

Remote or hybrid work requires approval under the team's process. Employees must maintain availability during agreed working hours, protect confidential information, use approved systems, and maintain a safe work environment.

Availability and meetings

Employees should keep calendars current, attend required meetings, communicate schedule changes, and use asynchronous updates when appropriate. Managers should set clear expectations and respect reasonable boundaries outside working hours.

5. Leave, Holidays & Time Off

Leave administration

Employees should submit leave requests through the designated system as early as reasonably possible and obtain approval where required. Unexpected illness or emergencies should be reported promptly under the team's notification procedure.

Leave categories

Depending on location and eligibility, leave may include annual or vacation leave, sick leave, public holidays, parental leave, family or caregiving leave, bereavement leave, medical leave, and other statutory or company-provided leave.

Entitlements and carryover

Specific balances, accrual rates, documentation requirements, carryover rules, and holiday calendars must be defined in the applicable local policy and must meet legal requirements. HR can explain the rules applicable to each employee.

Medical and sensitive information

Employees should provide only documentation reasonably required by law or policy. Medical and other sensitive information should be handled confidentially and shared only with authorized personnel who need it.

6. Compensation, Expenses & Benefits

Payroll

Employees should review payslips and promptly report suspected errors to Payroll or HR. Pay dates, deductions, tax treatment, and final pay are governed by payroll schedules, agreements, and applicable law.

Benefits

Eligibility, enrollment windows, dependents, coverage, exclusions, and claim procedures are described in the relevant plan documents. Where plan documents conflict with this summary, the formal plan documents and applicable law control.

Business expenses

Reasonable, necessary business expenses must be supported by itemized receipts and submitted within the stated deadline. Personal expenses, duplicate claims, and knowingly inaccurate claims are prohibited.

Payroll and banking security

Changes to bank or payroll details must be submitted through approved secure channels. Employees should verify unusual requests and never disclose passwords or one-time authentication codes.

7. Performance, Learning & Career Development

Performance expectations

Managers should communicate role responsibilities, objectives, and success measures. Performance discussions may occur periodically and should provide specific feedback, recognize contributions, and identify support or development needs.

Development and training

Employees should complete mandatory training by the assigned deadline and discuss development goals with their manager. The company may provide role-related learning, mentoring, or career opportunities based on business needs.

Performance concerns

When performance or conduct falls below expectations, the company may clarify expectations, provide coaching, set improvement goals, and review progress. The process may vary based on the seriousness of the issue and applicable law.

8. Workplace Health, Safety & Security

Safe workplace

Employees must follow safety procedures, use equipment as instructed, report hazards and injuries promptly, and avoid actions that put themselves or others at unreasonable risk.

Emergency response

Employees should know local emergency exits, evacuation procedures, first-aid contacts, and incident-reporting channels. In an immediate emergency, contact local emergency services first.

Fitness for duty

Employees must be fit to perform their duties safely. Working while impaired in a way that creates a safety risk is prohibited, subject to applicable law and any lawful accommodation requirements.

Workplace security

Badges, keys, devices, and access credentials must not be shared. Visitors should follow sign-in and escort procedures. Lost devices, suspected theft, or unauthorized access must be reported promptly.

9. Anti-Harassment, Bullying & Reporting

Prohibited conduct

Harassment, sexual harassment, bullying, threats, discrimination, and retaliation are not acceptable. The company will address concerns in accordance with applicable law and its investigation procedures.

How to report

Employees may contact their manager, HR, a designated ethics or compliance contact, or an alternative reporting channel if their manager is involved. Reports should include relevant details when possible, but employees do not need to investigate concerns themselves.

Review and confidentiality

The company will review reports promptly and impartially to the extent practicable. Information will be shared only as needed to assess and address the concern, subject to legal obligations and fair-process requirements.

No retaliation

Retaliation against anyone who raises a concern in good faith or participates in an investigation is prohibited. Knowingly false statements may be addressed through a fair process; a report is not improper merely because it cannot be substantiated.

10. Information Security, Privacy & Acceptable Use

Approved systems

Company systems and data should be used for authorized business purposes and in accordance with IT guidance. Employees must use approved software, keep devices updated, lock unattended screens, and follow multi-factor authentication requirements.

Passwords and phishing

Use unique, strong passwords and approved password-management tools. Never share credentials. Verify unexpected links, attachments, payment requests, and requests for sensitive information; report suspected phishing or compromise immediately.

Personal data

Collect, access, use, retain, and share personal data only for legitimate authorized purposes. Follow data-protection rules, retention schedules, and procedures for access requests, corrections, incidents, and deletion.

AI tools and external services

Only use company-approved AI tools and external services for company work. Do not submit confidential, personal, regulated, or customer information to unapproved tools. Verify generated content before relying on it and follow applicable intellectual-property and data-protection rules.

Monitoring and privacy notice

Any monitoring of company systems, devices, or premises must be authorized, proportionate, transparent where required, and consistent with applicable law and published notices. This handbook does not itself establish a monitoring program.

11. Confidentiality, Records & Intellectual Property

Confidential information

Non-public business, technical, financial, employee, supplier, and customer information must be protected and disclosed only to authorized recipients for legitimate purposes. These duties are subject to legal rights to report wrongdoing or make protected disclosures.

Document management

Business records must be accurate, complete, and stored in approved locations. Employees must follow retention schedules and preserve records subject to a legal hold or investigation; they must not destroy, conceal, or falsify records.

Intellectual property

Ownership and permitted use of work product, inventions, code, designs, and other intellectual property are governed by applicable law and signed agreements. Employees should consult Legal or HR when ownership or third-party rights are unclear.

External sharing

Before sharing information with a customer, supplier, or public forum, confirm the recipient is authorized and use approved transfer methods. Report accidental disclosure immediately so the company can limit harm.

12. Social Media, Public Statements & Media Requests

Personal expression

Employees may express personal views, subject to applicable law and their obligations to protect confidential information and avoid unlawful harassment or threats. Personal accounts should not imply that an employee speaks for the company unless authorized.

Company representation

Only designated spokespersons may make official statements on behalf of the company. Refer press, investor, legal, and regulatory inquiries to the designated communications or legal contact.

Online conduct

Do not post confidential information, customer data, internal credentials, or non-public business records. Follow applicable rules when using company branding, discussing work, or publishing content created as part of your role.

13. Company Property, Travel & Expenses

Equipment and assets

Company devices, software, access cards, funds, and other assets must be used responsibly and protected from loss or unauthorized use. Employees must report damage, loss, or theft promptly.

Business travel

Travel must be approved in advance under the applicable travel policy. Employees should use approved booking channels, follow safety guidance, retain receipts, and submit expense claims accurately and on time.

Purchasing and suppliers

Purchases and supplier commitments must follow delegated authority, procurement procedures, and conflict-of-interest rules. Employees must not split purchases or bypass approval controls to avoid limits.

14. Disciplinary Process & Grievances

Fair review

Concerns about conduct or policy compliance will be reviewed fairly and proportionately. Depending on the facts, steps may include coaching, a written warning, a performance plan, suspension where lawful, or termination, subject to applicable law and agreements.

Employee response

Where appropriate, employees will be informed of the concern and given a reasonable opportunity to respond. The company may investigate, review relevant records, and speak with witnesses while respecting privacy and legal obligations.

Grievances and appeals

Employees who believe a workplace decision or treatment is unfair should raise the concern with their manager or HR, or use an alternative channel when needed. The company will explain any review or appeal process available.

15. Separation of Employment & Return of Property

Notice and transition

Resignation should be submitted in writing to the manager and HR in accordance with the employment agreement and applicable law. The company will communicate notice, handover, final-pay, benefits, and exit procedures.

Return of property

By the required date, employees must return company equipment, access cards, records, keys, and other assets. Company information must not be copied, retained, or transferred to personal accounts except where expressly authorized.

Access and continuing obligations

System access may be adjusted or revoked as part of the exit process. Any continuing confidentiality, intellectual-property, or other obligations are governed by applicable law and signed agreements; employees retain any rights that cannot lawfully be waived.

16. Policy Administration & Employee Acknowledgment

Policy ownership and updates

HR coordinates handbook administration with Legal, IT, Finance, Security, and other policy owners. The company should review this handbook periodically and whenever material legal or operational changes occur.

Questions and exceptions

Questions should be directed to HR or the policy owner. Exceptions require documented approval from an authorized person and may not override applicable law.

Acknowledgment

Employees may be asked to acknowledge receipt and understanding of the handbook. Acknowledgment confirms receipt; it does not necessarily mean agreement with every statement or waive legal rights. The organization should obtain local legal review of acknowledgment wording.

Employee Acknowledgment (Sample)

I acknowledge that I have received access to this sample employee handbook and understand that I should ask HR about any policy I do not understand. I understand that applicable law, my employment agreement, and formal benefit-plan documents may govern specific matters. This sample must be replaced or approved by the organization before being used as an official policy.

Employee name:	
Signature:	
Date:	
HR representative (optional):	

End of sample handbook. Before adopting, customize company name, jurisdiction, leave and pay details, reporting contacts, approval thresholds, IT rules, and any industry-specific requirements.